

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Environmental Consulting English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For environmental consultants, remediation managers, sustainability analysts, field scientists, permitting specialists, ESG teams, and environmental project managers.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Phase I and Phase II Site Assessments

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

02 Sampling Plans and Data Quality

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

03 Permitting and Agency Coordination

Clarify missing information before responding.

04 Remediation Options and Risk

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

05 Regulatory Compliance and Audits

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

06 Sustainability and ESG Reporting

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

07 Community and Stakeholder Meetings

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

08 Proposal, Scope, and Client Expectations

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Phase I and Phase II Site Assessments

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A site-assessment summary says no further questions remain, but one historical record has not been obtained.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: Phase I ESA, REC, Phase II, due diligence.

Model response

The review is incomplete because that historical record is missing. I'll identify the information gap and its significance for the assessment rather than imply that all relevant questions have been resolved.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. B - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. A - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 · Conversations

1. One historical record is still missing - Fictional due-diligence review: a site-assessment summary says no questions remain, although one requested historical record is unavailable. This is language practice, not an environmental opinion.

2. A site visit is not subsurface sampling - Separate fictional due-diligence case: a site visit is complete; no subsurface samples were collected, and a draft describes the ground as tested.

3. A neighbor's record does not classify this property - Separate fictional assessment case: a historical record concerns a neighboring parcel; the relationship to the subject property has not been evaluated.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An old assessment has a different boundary

A fictional client supplies an old site assessment covering the northern parcel only. The current purchase includes both northern and southern parcels. No assessment of the southern parcel is supplied. Discuss the document's scope and missing evidence.

Role A: Due-diligence coordinator: explain why the old report cannot automatically cover the whole purchase.

Role B: Client transaction manager: ask what the qualified assessor needs to review next.

Possible opening: The old report covers the northern parcel, but our current purchase also includes the southern parcel.

Success checks

- Identify the boundary mismatch.
- Preserve the old report's actual scope.
- Request qualified review of the unassessed portion.

Add a complication: The client asks you to relabel the old report as covering the combined property.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Sampling Plans and Data Quality

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A sample record omits a transfer signature. The laboratory result is available, but the chain-of-custody record needs review.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: sampling plan, chain of custody, detection limit, QA/QC.

Model response

Could the responsible team review the missing transfer record and document the resolution? I'll flag the gap in the data-quality discussion instead of treating the paperwork as complete.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. A - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. C - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 · Conversations

1. A missing transfer signature needs review - Fictional sampling-record case: laboratory results are available, but the chain-of-custody record lacks a transfer signature; data usability is not determined here.
2. Request the reporting limit behind a nondetect - Separate fictional laboratory discussion: a result is labeled nondetect, but the reporting information needed to interpret that label is missing from the supplied extract.

3. A duplicate label needs a sample match - Separate fictional sampling case: two labels in a field log use the same sample identifier, while the sampling plan lists distinct locations.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A laboratory qualifier is missing from the table

A fictional laboratory report includes a qualifier on sample S4, but the client summary omits it. Its meaning has not been checked. Request the qualified reviewer's explanation before the result is presented without qualification.

Role A: Project analyst: identify S4 as the affected sample and request the complete qualifier text and its interpretation.

Role B: Laboratory liaison: obtain the authorized explanation without inventing its significance.

Possible opening: Could you clarify the qualifier on S4 and how it should appear in the client summary?

Success checks

- Preserve the laboratory result and qualifier.
- Ask for interpretation from the appropriate reviewer.
- Keep data usability unresolved until reviewed.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to delete the qualifier from both places because it looks confusing.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Permitting and Agency Coordination

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

An agency comment requests additional modeling but does not specify which scenario the team believes is missing.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: permit, agency comment, public notice, modeling.

Model response

Could we confirm which scenario and supporting information the comment refers to? I'll draft a focused clarification question and identify our proposed response for review.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. C - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Which modeling scenario is missing? - Fictional agency coordination: a comment asks for additional modeling but does not identify the scenario the team believes is missing.
2. A comment number without a document version - Separate fictional permit review: an agency message references comment 7, but two reviewed document versions use that number for different subjects.
3. Public notice timing or approval timing? - Separate fictional agency-meeting preparation: a calendar entry says notice date, but the team has not established whether it refers to publication or a response deadline.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The agency asks for an updated map

A fictional agency comment requests an updated map without specifying whether it needs the revised project boundary or new sampling locations. Both changes exist in draft. Clarify the requested content before the map team proceeds.

Role A: Environmental project coordinator: ask which mapped changes and version the comment concerns.

Role B: Agency liaison: acknowledge the ambiguity and seek the reviewer's clarification.

Possible opening: Could you clarify whether updated map refers to the project boundary, the sampling locations, or both?

Success checks

- Identify the two possible meanings.
- Seek confirmation without silently expanding scope.
- Distinguish a revised submission from agency approval.

Add a complication: The client wants the map described as agency-approved as soon as it is revised.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Remediation Options and Risk

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

CASE

Two remediation options have different implementation times and monitoring needs. A client asks which is simply "best."

Teach this move

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: remediation, exposure pathway, cap, long-term monitoring.

Model response

The options address the problem in different ways and have different monitoring needs. Let's compare them against the agreed objectives and site conditions before recommending a preferred approach.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Second-round challenge

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Language-check answers

1. B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. A - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

05 · Conversations

1. Faster implementation, longer monitoring - Fictional comparison for language practice: option A is estimated at four weeks with three years of monitoring; B at twelve weeks with one year. Suitability and other costs need professional review.
2. A cap proposal needs defined comparison criteria - Separate fictional client meeting: a cap concept and an excavation concept are under preliminary review; no cost, safety, or suitability conclusion has been established.

3. Different monitoring scopes hide the real cost - Separate fictional comparison: proposal A includes quarterly reports for two years; B's lower quoted price includes only one annual report. The technical monitoring plan is not being selected here.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Compare disruption on the same calendar

Two fictional remediation schedules use different units: A states twenty working days, B states four calendar weeks. Access restrictions and start dates are unknown. Discuss why these figures alone do not establish which is faster for the client.

Role A: Project planner: identify the differing time bases and missing assumptions.

Role B: Client operations manager: ask for a comparable schedule and state the importance of access continuity.

Possible opening: The schedules use different time bases, so we need matching assumptions before calling one faster.

Success checks

- Distinguish working days from calendar weeks.
- Ask for matching schedule and access assumptions.
- Avoid guaranteeing operational continuity or technical suitability.

Add a complication: The client wants you to guarantee uninterrupted access without an assessed access plan.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Regulatory Compliance and Audits

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

A compliance review has six findings. Four have documented corrective actions; two still lack an assigned owner.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: compliance audit, corrective action, recordkeeping, inspection.

Model response

Four findings have documented actions. Two still need owners and target dates. I'll make those open decisions visible in the review update and distinguish planned actions from completed ones.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. A - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. C - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

05 · Conversations

1. Four actions documented, two owners missing - Fictional compliance review: six findings exist; four have documented corrective actions and two have no assigned owner. Verification of effectiveness is not supplied.
2. Inspection completed, evidence review pending - Separate fictional audit case: a facility inspection visit is complete, but photographs and maintenance records have not yet been reviewed against the findings.

3. Training attendance does not close the finding - Separate fictional corrective-action case: a recordkeeping training session is delivered, but a planned sample check of later records has not occurred.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A corrective action changes owner

A fictional audit action was assigned to a manager who has moved departments. The action remains open, and the proposed replacement has not accepted it. Give a status update and request confirmed reassignment.

Role A: Compliance coordinator: describe the open action and unaccepted reassignment.

Role B: Department lead: ask what evidence and responsibility transfer are needed.

Possible opening: The action remains open, and the proposed new owner has not yet accepted responsibility.

Success checks

- Separate reassignment from action completion.
- Identify the missing acceptance.
- Agree who will confirm ownership and correct the misleading status.

Add a complication: The dashboard automatically shows reassigned as complete.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Sustainability and ESG Reporting

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A sustainability draft says the company is carbon neutral, but the supporting calculation covers only selected operations.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: ESG, Scope 1, Scope 2, Scope 3, carbon neutral.

Model response

The calculation does not yet support that broad claim. I'll state the included operations and reporting boundary clearly, then route the proposed wording for the appropriate review.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 · Conversations

1. Selected operations do not support a company-wide claim - Fictional sustainability review: a carbon-neutral claim is drafted, but the supporting calculation covers selected operations only; no certification or claim validity is established.

2. A smaller footprint may reflect a smaller boundary - Separate fictional emissions comparison: this year's inventory excludes a sold facility that was included last year; a like-for-like comparison has not been prepared.
3. A supplier survey is not verified emissions data - Separate fictional ESG case: thirty suppliers answered a questionnaire, but their emissions figures have not been checked and the remaining suppliers have not responded.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A renewable-energy claim uses an unreviewed document

A fictional company has received a supplier document about electricity sourcing, but its dates and covered sites have not been checked. A draft calls every office fully renewable. Discuss the evidence needed before making that claim.

Role A: ESG reviewer: identify the unverified dates and site coverage.

Role B: Communications lead: propose a status statement that does not claim verified sourcing.

Possible opening: We have the supplier document, but its dates and site coverage haven't been verified against the proposed claim.

Success checks

- Distinguish document receipt from evidence verification.
- Identify dates and site coverage as open questions.
- Avoid company-wide claims from unreviewed material.

Add a complication: A manager wants the claim used immediately because the supplier logo looks authoritative.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Community and Stakeholder Meetings

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

Residents ask whether a preliminary result proves that an entire area is safe. Sampling covered only specified locations and conditions.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: stakeholder, plume, exposure, risk communication.

Model response

The result describes the sampled locations and conditions. It does not answer every question about the wider area. We should explain the findings, their limits, and the next planned information step clearly.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. B - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. A - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. A sampled location is not the whole area - Fictional community-meeting preparation: preliminary sampling covers specified locations and conditions; no area-wide safety conclusion is supplied.
2. A plume map is not a personal exposure record - Separate fictional stakeholder briefing: a preliminary map shows a modeled plume extent, but individual exposure information is not available.

3. A screening value is not a complete risk conclusion - Separate fictional risk-communication rehearsal: a table compares preliminary results with a screening value; the qualified risk assessment remains open.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A result applies to one season

A fictional community report contains samples collected during one dry-season visit. A resident asks whether it describes conditions throughout the year. No seasonal comparison is available. Explain the sampling boundary and agree a follow-up question.

Role A: Environmental liaison: explain what the single visit establishes without predicting other seasons.

Role B: Community association coordinator: paraphrase the limitation and ask what further assessment could clarify it.

Possible opening: These results describe the sampled conditions during one visit, not a measured comparison across every season.

Success checks

- State the single-visit boundary plainly.
- Avoid universal safety or danger claims.
- Refer the seasonal question for qualified assessment.

Add a complication: The coordinator asks for a yes-or-no assurance about all future conditions.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Proposal, Scope, and Client Expectations

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

CASE

A client requests additional sampling outside the agreed scope. The team has not assessed the extra time and cost.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Vocabulary to check: scope, assumption, deliverable, change order.

Model response

We can assess the additional sampling as a scope change. Could we confirm the question it needs to answer, then provide the time and cost implications before agreeing to the work?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Second-round challenge

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Language-check answers

1. A - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule. The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.
2. C - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope. This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

05 · Conversations

1. Additional samples need a scope review - Fictional proposal discussion: a client requests additional sampling beyond the agreed scope; extra time, cost, and technical requirements are unassessed.
2. An early briefing versus a final report - Separate fictional client case: a final report is pending qualified review; the team can assess an interim verbal briefing of verified progress without releasing final conclusions.

3. A new audience changes the presentation scope - Separate fictional proposal case: a consultant's scope includes one technical client meeting; the client requests two public stakeholder sessions with new presentation material.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Translate the report summary for a new audience

A fictional consulting agreement covers an English technical summary. The client requests a translated spoken briefing for a community group. Language support, review, cost, and availability have not been assessed. Negotiate what proposal to seek, not the translation itself.

Role A: Consulting coordinator: identify the added language-support and briefing scope.

Role B: Client liaison: choose whether to retain the original deliverable or seek an additional proposal.

Possible opening: We can assess a translated briefing, but language support, review, cost, and availability still need agreement.

Success checks

- Separate the original summary from the new spoken service.
- Identify language and technical review needs.
- Keep cost, timing, and authorization conditional on assessment.

Add a complication: The client asks a bilingual colleague to improvise technical conclusions without review.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

GHG Protocol: corporate standard

<https://ghgprotocol.org/corporate-standard>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Adapt a partner or class activity

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Environmental Consulting English

Professional audience: environmental consultants, remediation managers, sustainability analysts, field scientists, permitting specialists, ESG teams, and environmental project managers

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Phase I and Phase II Site Assessments

Original fictional case: A site-assessment summary says no further questions remain, but one historical record has not been obtained.

Language workshop: Match certainty to evidence

Communication goal: Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

Language guidance: Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): The available evidence shows ... / This may indicate ..., but ... / We have not yet established whether ...

Vocabulary: Phase I ESA: An environmental site assessment reviewing records and site information to identify relevant environmental concerns. / REC: Recognized environmental condition: a defined environmental-assessment term concerning hazardous substances or petroleum at a property. / Phase II: A further environmental investigation often involving sampling to assess concerns identified at a site. / due diligence: Structured review of facts, risks, obligations, and evidence before a transaction, onboarding,

investment, or decision.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The review is incomplete because that historical record is missing. I'll identify the information gap and its significance for the assessment rather than imply that all relevant questions have been resolved.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt this material for a teaching session

1. Ask me one brief planning question covering learner support needs, group size and available time. Offer a default of two B2 learners and 20 minutes. Stop and wait; use the default only if I choose it.
2. Create a timed plan using the supplied case or dialogue, its actual terminology and one narrow language goal. Include an individual first attempt, partner exchange, focused feedback and a retry. Keep the total within the time I choose. State what the learner should be able to communicate at the end.
3. Provide separate role cards for two or three professional speakers. Each card needs an objective, known information and one question to resolve. Label any invented private information as a variation; do not contradict shared facts. Do not place the model answer on the learner cards.
4. Add a B1 support option with useful frames, a B2 independent task and a C1 extension involving a plausible competing constraint. Maintain the same professional meaning across levels. Explain unfamiliar terms without removing the field's normal language. Include a workable solo alternative.
5. Put teacher notes and suggested responses in a clearly separate section after the learner material. Include likely misunderstandings and a short observation checklist for facts, clarity, tone and next step. Accept multiple successful formulations. Finish with one exit question and a delayed-recall task; identify what the teacher should check before use.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Adjust tone and register

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Environmental Consulting English

Professional audience: environmental consultants, remediation managers, sustainability analysts, field scientists, permitting specialists, ESG teams, and environmental project managers

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Phase I and Phase II Site Assessments

Original fictional case: A site-assessment summary says no further questions remain, but one historical record has not been obtained.

Language workshop: Match certainty to evidence

Communication goal: Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

Language guidance: Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): The available evidence shows ... / This may indicate ..., but ... / We have not yet established whether ...

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Match the language to the listener

1. Choose a short message or utterance from the reference and quote it exactly. Identify its purpose and likely audience. Ask me to choose a new audience: a close colleague, a decision-maker, or an external reader who may not know the jargon. Stop and wait.
2. Ask me to adapt that message for the chosen reader, keeping its facts and degree of certainty unchanged. Offer a short frame only if I request help. Wait for my attempt before showing alternatives.
3. Discuss at most three choices in my version: directness, specialist vocabulary and interpersonal tone. Explain when a direct request is clearer than extra politeness, and when an unfamiliar abbreviation needs expansion. Avoid cultural stereotypes or claims that one nationality always communicates a certain way.
4. Show two natural alternatives, such as a concise spoken version and a more explicit written version. Explain the tradeoff in each. Do not turn a request into an order, a possibility into a promise, or a pending decision into approval.
5. Ask me to respond to one realistic follow-up from the new reader, then wait. Finish by asking me to adapt the message for a second audience without losing its core meaning. Give feedback only after the attempt.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level